

Whether Eternal Matter Matters?

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April 4, 2023

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Comp. Lit. 12

4 April 2023

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Some of the greatest philosophical and theological minds have put forward arguments regarding the idea of eternal matter. A vast majority of Hellenistic philosophers concluded that there was no definitive beginning to all that is. However, it is written, “In the beginning God created heaven, and earth” (Gen. 1.1). By Faith, it is understood that matter is not eternal. St. Thomas Aquinas, in the interest of the pursuit of truth, unravels this seeming contradiction. This issue is not just the stuff of ancient philosophers. In our modern world, leading scientific theories assert the belief in eternal matter. Modernity has tragically brushed off the importance of engaging in dialogue about the causal relationship between Creator and created. Therefore, it is undoubtedly important to entertain and discuss these profound ideas in the light of reason. I say that, whether or not matter is eternal, both cases necessarily require a Creator.

A first objector might begin by questioning the logical plausibility of an eternal world, arguing that God could not have created it, as it has always existed. To be created means to have a beginning, leaving no room for the possibility of eternal matter. Therefore, God’s act of “creation can only be [one of] control, limitation, [and] ordering” (Carroll).

A second objector might argue against this possibility of eternal matter by charting its causality back to its origin. If this matter is indeed eternal, its existence must be infinitely traceable. God, being the First Cause, must be the end to which every other cause can be traced.

That which does not have a beginning in existence does not need a cause. However, if it exists without a cause, there would be two uncaused causes, two Gods, which is absurd.

On the contrary, Dr. William Carroll writes: "...a proper understanding of faith and reason requires us to admit the intelligibility of matter's being [both] eternal and created" (Carroll).

I say that even if matter was indeed eternal, it is no logical impossibility that it also is created. That is, the thesis of the eternity of matter does not negate the need for a First Cause. With regards to terms, matter is essentially the physical 'stuff' out of which all physical things are made. The question at hand pertains to whether, if this 'stuff' has always existed, it would have any need of a cause. It is important here to qualify the essential difference between God as First Cause, acting per se, and accidental causes set into motion by some outside agent. All accidental causes are made up of potency and act, and that which they are the cause of must also be made up of these characteristics (Aquinas, *Commentary on the Physics*). A common misconception of the modern world is the idea that God acts in the same way as an accidental cause, requiring something with potency and in time in order to cause. However, God causes all things; He neither needs nor relies on them, but rather exists outside the limits of potency and act. His act of creation does not require time, or some potency to act on. The temporal status of the matter is entirely irrelevant to the reality of this revealed truth. This idea of eternal matter is fascinating because it forces us to recognize a more profound way of understanding how our Creator creates. In other words, creation is not just the mere temporal beginning of existence, but an ongoing act of total dependency of the creature upon the Creator for its being. This is not to say that discussing these ideas does not matter, for it can bring about a greater understanding of how God acts. Rather, it would not matter if matter was eternal, as there is still a need for

a First Cause. God is in no way altered or changed. That matter has a temporal beginning is revealed to us in Genesis and is a truth known by Faith, not reason.

In response to the first objector who argued that God could have only acted as a sculptor of matter if it has always been in existence, I say that the presupposition that God cannot act outside of temporal order is not tenable. St. Thomas Aquinas argues that God is prior to all His effects, but not in a temporal way (Aquinas, *De Aeternitate*). Thus, it is possible to say that, since God is not contingent upon His creation, He could have acted upon it, not as an outside sculptor but simultaneously with his effect, as a per se cause. Further, matter which is both eternal and created taken at face value seems inherently contradictory; however, it is necessary to distinguish between eternity with respect to both God and creation. God is eternal in that he is beyond any temporal categorization. An eternal world, on the other hand, would fall within a temporal categorization stretched out over an infinite period, with no beginning or end. Aquinas describes creation as a dependency in being, not merely its beginning (Aquinas, *De Aeternitate*). This understanding of God being the First Cause, not in the sense of coming before any following causes, but rather in the sense of being entirely fundamental, is necessary in order to come to terms with the possibility of eternal matter.

In response to the second objector who argued the logical impossibility of matter apart from God, I say that though they are correct in stating that nothing can exist apart from God. The central error lies in the conclusion that an infinitely traceable temporal effect must necessarily be without the need for a cause. For if given a cause, the effect does not exist simultaneously with it, there must be some third, outside cause at play. However, Aquinas writes that God “never lacks any kind of complementary cause in order to produce an effect” (Aquinas, *De Aeternitate*).

Therefore, to say that His creation exists simultaneously with Him, regardless of its temporal nature, is tenable since He is the constant cause of all of His effects.

In conclusion, I say that the concept of eternal matter in no way nullifies the need for it to be created. St. Thomas Aquinas' treatise *On the Eternity of The World* clarifies that there is nothing illogical in saying that matter could have been created eternally. In fact, it reveals many beautiful truths with regards to how creation came about. It shows us that God is constantly causing all of the created order to have existence. The simple fact that he could have fashioned matter eternally is fascinating and undoubtedly helpful in defending the Faith against attacks on these grounds. However, this notion of eternal matter does not undermine God in any way. It is simply how He chose to act, mysterious as it may be to us.

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